

India had agreed to separate its civilian reactors from those it designated as military and bring these in phases under permanent safeguards of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). Delhi then signed an India-specific protocol with the IAEA at record speed with the US providing "helping muscle" as one diplomat put it. The hardest part both India and the US knew was to convince NSG members, many of them the ayatollahs of non-

China. The balance had tilted in India's favour after, in a dramatic policy declaration, Mukherjee reiterated India's commitment to non-proliferation and its voluntary unilateral moratorium on testing nuclear weapons. According to an American negotiator, "It just shifted the entire perception and changed the character of the conversation."

Till then some of the NSG members were hoping that they could squeeze more out of India. When the first round

said, "Like a great tennis double team, it was truly a joint venture." The Indian team argued that if there was annual review, then no one would invest crores to set up reactors. The US then leant on the NSG members.

As the rounds of negotiations proceeded, the trust between the two countries grew. They had both drawn up redlines they were unwilling to cross. India wanted no conditions tagged on other than what it had agreed to with the US in earlier agreements, especially on the subject of nuclear tests. The buzz word was a "clean" exemption. For the US negotiators it would look odd that countries like Austria and New Zealand, with really nothing to sell, would be able to get India give up much more than what it had conceded under the 123 Agreement. The two countries then worked hard on the hold-outs to yield, with both Bush and Mammohan getting on the phones to personally speak to some leaders. As a negotiator said, "Ultimately it had to be posed as a choice of do you want to be the only one who stood in India's way. And then it was a question of not just India but the US also." China, though it came in for flak from India, had given its word that it wouldn't block a consensus. While the waiver allows India to trade with NSG countries, India would have to wait till the 123 Agreement is ratified by the US Congress to buy stuff from America.

For both India and the US, the hard-fought battle brings with it major gains. As Saran says, "The fact that the international rules which were earlier being directed against India were now being adjusted to accommodate us is a significant development." Ashley Tellis, a senior associate at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, believes that the nuclear negotiations showed that "the US still has the enormous power of persuasion despite what happened in Iraq". For Menon, the victory is all "about India's future and about what we think of ourselves". He believes that India can now go out and deal with the world as an equal and do so with confidence. India had become a significant part of the global architecture. And no one seems to have noticed, but unlike in the past, it is no more hypenated with Pakistan. In short, last week India had truly arrived. ■



THE US A TEAM & how they did it



AP PHOTO/ SCOTT APPLEWHITE

BUSH: Convinced of the need to engage India, he pulled out all the stops and used his clout to bring recalcitrant nations around.



CONDOLEEZZA RICE: The driver, she went out of the way to accommodate India's concerns.



STEVE HADLEY: Played a major role in convincing his own establishment to back the deal strongly.



W. BURNS: Came on board recently but demonstrated firmness and flexibility when needed.



JOHN ROODS: Key US interlocutor in Vienna, broke through the naysayers lobby.



NICHOLAS BURNS: Part of the original N-deal team. Negotiated the 123 Agreement.



DAVID MULFORD: The envoy used his personal relationship with Bush to keep the pressure up.

proliferation, to amend its rules.

Under the deal, America would shepherd the deal through the NSG. India, since it wasn't a member of the group, was forced to watch from the sidelines, as Menon was doing that morning. The previous two days had seen a hard-fought battle that whittled down the naysayers to just four—Austria, New Zealand, Ireland and

of negotiations had begun a fortnight before, they had wanted India to give up its right to test its nuclear weapons and join the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT). Some others had wanted sensitive nuclear technology to be denied to India and that any concessions made would be subject to annual reviews. The US and Indian negotiating teams worked, as another negotiator